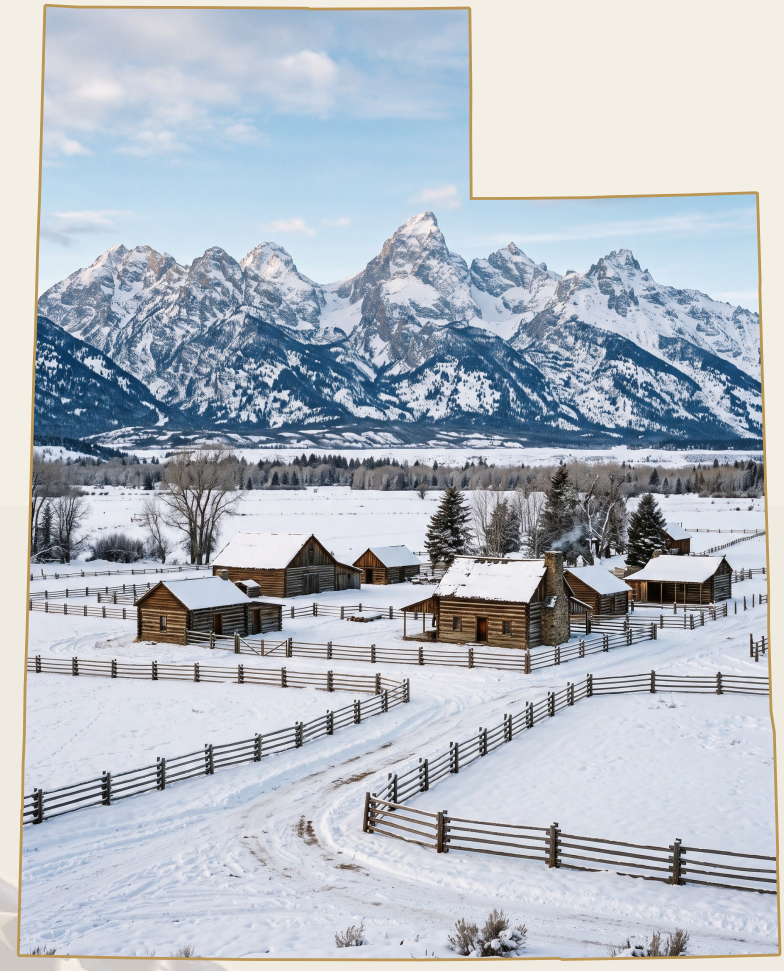
UTAH

The Beehive State



In the tight-knit pioneer settlements that spread across the Salt Lake Valley in the latter half of the 1800s, food was never just food. It was a language—spoken in loaves of bread left on doorsteps, in kettles of soup carried across frozen fields, and in the warm, golden casseroles that appeared without fail whenever a family was too grief-stricken to feed itself.

When Brigham Young led the first company of Latter-day Saint pioneers into the Salt Lake Valley in July of 1847, they arrived in a land that offered little welcome. The soil was dry, the growing season was short, and survival required something the settlers had already perfected on the long journey west—the radical act of feeding one another. Women organized quickly and deliberately. The Relief Society, the women's organization of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints formally established in Nauvoo, Illinois in 1842, became the backbone of community care on the frontier. Its members catalogued who was sick, who had just given birth, who had lost a husband to the canyon or the cold—and they cooked accordingly.

The casserole that would eventually earn the name "Funeral Potatoes" was born from both necessity and ingenuity. Potatoes grew reliably in Utah's mountain valleys—particularly in Cache Valley in the north, where the soil was rich and the irrigation water ran cold from the Wasatch Range. Cheese, sour cream, and butter were products of the dairy farms that dotted communities like Provo, Logan, and the small farming settlements of Sanpete County. These were ingredients that kept, that stretched, and that could feed a crowd with very little fuss. Crushed cornflakes or crackers pressed across the top added a golden, satisfying crunch that made something humble feel like it had been made with intention—because it always had been.

For generations, the dish traveled in the hands of Relief Society women, carried in cloth-covered pans to the church halls and family homes where the bereaved gathered after a burial. It required no explanation and no ceremony. It simply appeared, warm and reliable, at the moment when a family needed to be fed and couldn't imagine how they would manage it. In a culture that placed deep value on community, self-reliance, and the care of neighbors, a pan of these potatoes was as sincere an expression of love as any words spoken over the grave.

By the time Utah became a state in 1896, the dish had already outgrown its somber occasion. It appeared at church potlucks, harvest dinners, wedding luncheons, and holiday tables—beloved enough that Utahns eventually gave it its honest name without embarrassment. When the 2002 Winter Olympics came to Salt Lake City, Funeral Potatoes were celebrated on a commemorative pin, officially cementing their place not just in Utah kitchens, but in Utah identity.

What makes this dish so irresistible is the same thing that made it indispensable for over a century—it is deeply, unashamedly comforting. The creamy, cheesy interior gives way to a bubbling, crispy top that is nearly impossible to resist pulling apart before the pan even reaches the table. Make it once and you will understand immediately why generations of Utahns turned to it in their hardest moments. It doesn't just feed people. It steadies them.

FUNERAL POTATOES

Even the humblest dish, made with love, has the power to comfort a grieving heart and feed the soul.

Yield: 10–12 servings

INGREDIENTS

- 1 (30 oz.) bag frozen shredded hash browns, thawed
- 1 can (10.5 oz.) cream of chicken soup
- 2 cups sour cream
- 2 cups sharp cheddar cheese, shredded
- ½ cup unsalted butter, melted (divided)
- 1 small onion, finely chopped (optional)
- 1 tsp garlic powder
- 1 tsp salt
- ½ tsp black pepper
- 3 cups cornflakes, lightly crushed

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Preheat*: Preheat the oven to 350°F (175°C) and grease a 9x13-inch baking dish.
2. *Mix base*: In a large bowl, combine thawed hash browns, cream of chicken soup, sour cream, cheddar cheese, ¼ cup melted butter, onion (if using), garlic powder, salt, and pepper. Stir until well blended.
3. *Assemble casserole*: Spread mixture evenly into the prepared baking dish.
4. *Prepare topping*: In a medium bowl, toss crushed cornflakes with remaining ¼ cup melted butter. Sprinkle evenly over potato mixture.
5. *Bake*: Place casserole in the oven and bake uncovered for 40–45 minutes, or until topping is golden brown and edges are bubbly.

